"THAT SHE'S SUCH A PROMINENT FEMALE IS SOMETHING THAT WE'RE HAPPY WITH"

ALAN MARTIN

A huge part of our current comic audience came via watching the movie first, and then digging into the character's history to find that she has this crazy, sprawling past."

It wasn't just Hollywood that was bedazzled by Tankie – she quickly became a symbolic icon of the growing empowerment of women in punk, indie and alternative cultures. All-girl band Fuzzbox dressed as Tank Girl for publicity shots, *Tank Girl* t-shirts sprang up that celebrated the 1990 Lesbian and Gay Pride March, Wrangler featured *Tank Girl* in a series of ads in 1991, while bands including Blur and Teenage Fanclub were open about their *Tank Girl* influence.

Just three years after her first appearance, *Tank Girl* was being published across Europe, as well as in South America, Japan and the US. Movie exploits aside, *Tank Girl* subsequently acquired a new clutch of celebrity fans, including Adam Ant, New Order and The Ramones.

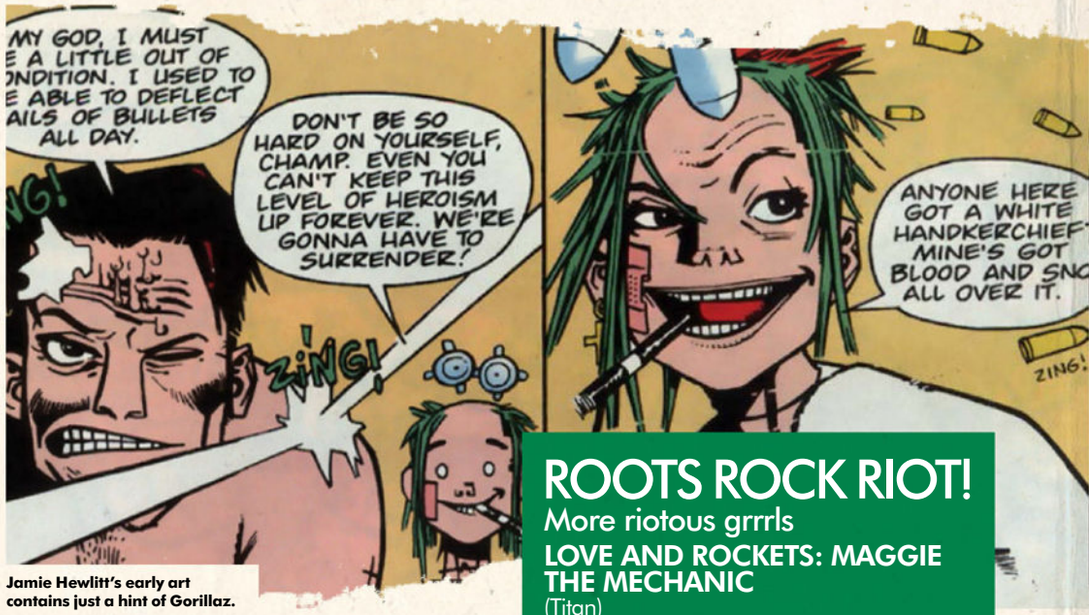
When *Vogue* caught up with the 'Bad Girl Fashion' that had hit the streets, it cited *Tank Girl* as a crucial influence. Model Sarah Stockbridge, a favourite of Vivienne Westwood, portrayed Tank Girl for *Elle*, *Time Out*, *Select* and *The Face*. And that's a lasting legacy – designer Henry Holland pointed to *Tank Girl* as influence for his late 2015 collection, and Petty mode Tank Girls are a favourite cosplay choice. The *Tank Girl* effect is everywhere, not least in the artists who have since inked her exploits after Hewlett moved on.

"All the *Tank Girl* artists are favourites of mine to some extent or other," says Johnson-Cadwell. "Then there are the *2000 AD* artists I grew up with, particularly Mike McMahon and Kevin O'Neill. So then that's a double score for McMahon, who has done both. He is a constant inspiration."

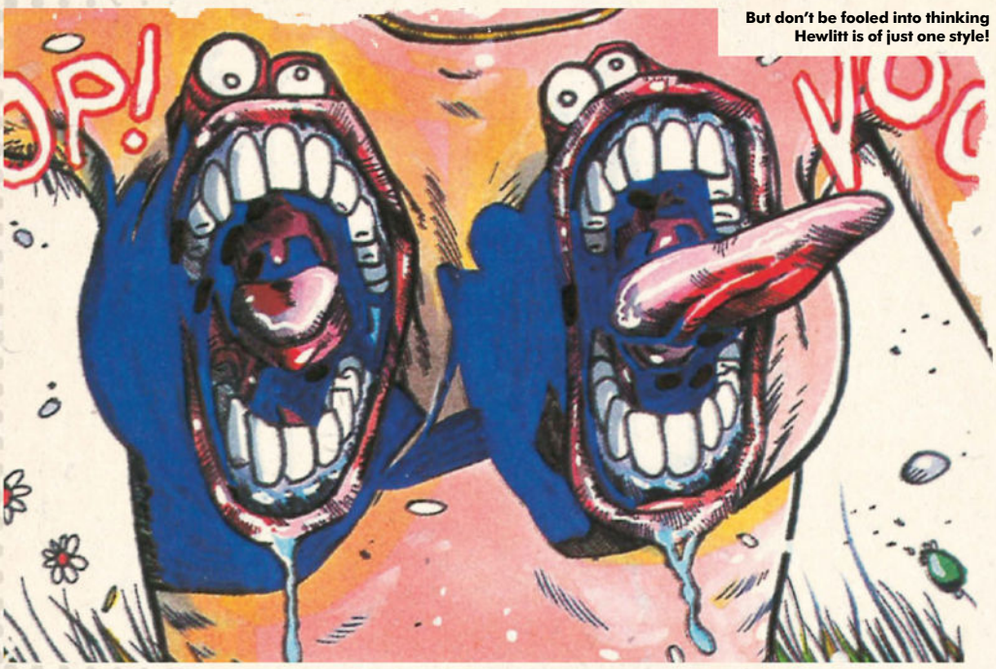
"At the top of the [influence] pile would probably be Hewlett, Simon Bisley, Jack Davis, J Scott Campbell, Don Bluth, Robert Crumb and Sam Kieth," Parson muses. "Then things like *Ren And Stimpy*, *Mad Max*, Russ Meyer and Ralph Bakshi movies too. "

So who is Tank Girl? The first comic opens with a kangaroo gang en route to break up a barby. Sporting belt buckles that spell 'crap', swilling beer and swinging guns, the 'roos descend on a celebrity barbecue ready to cause violence and mayhem. Nearby, a silhouetted figure stands in the shadows of a cave, bearing teeth and lazily drawing on a cigarette.

The crowded, cramped black and white panels of angular lines and grotesque characters give way to the 'CLANKY-CLANK-YOWZA!' of a tank plunging from a cliff into the fray below, mutilating and murdering 'roo



Jamie Hewlitt's early art contains just a hint of Gorillaz.



But don't be fooled into thinking Hewlitt is of just one style!

ROOTS ROCK RIOT!

More riotous grrrls

LOVE AND ROCKETS: MAGGIE THE MECHANIC

(Titan)

Jaime Hernandez



The proto-*Tank Girl* and one of the greatest stars of the multi award-winning *Love And Rockets* series, Maggie and her girlfriend, Hopey, make for the greatest Hernandez strips. Punk sci-fi at its best!

STARSTRUCK

(IDW)

Elaine Lee, Michael Wm Kaluta, Lee Moyer



The greatest science-fiction comic ever created, *Starstruck* remains a somewhat undiscovered gem, despite pioneering many of the techniques that the later *Watchmen* is credited with. An epic space opera that will seriously stretch your brain meats.

KILL YOUR BOYFRIEND/ VIMANARAMA

(DC Comics)

Grant Morrison, Philip Bond



Both comics are classics from Morrison's early days, the latter critically acclaimed and the former full of anarchic and gun-toting teenage vigour. Channelling *Heathers*, this has only recently been reprinted – the initial year of publication was just one year before Columbine.

HOPELESS SAVAGES: GREATEST HITS 2000-2010

(Oni Press)

Jen Van Meter, Christine Norrie et al



Zero's parents are punk superstars Dirk Hopeless and Nikki Savage, who have retired to comfy suburbia. When her parents are kidnapped though, she has to round up her goth sister Arsenal, neo-mod brother Twitch, and track down their estranged brother Rat, who rebelled against his parents in the only way he could think of – going corporate.

THE COMPLETE WIMMEN'S COMIX

(Fantagraphics)

Trina Robbins et al



Alternative comix weren't exactly a barrel of laughs for women in the early days, as money didn't determine which male artists stuck to their sexist guns. In 1972, *Wimmen's Comix* was born – a haven for ten women cartoonists to let loose their pens and subvert the medium. Newly collected for 2016.